

The Battle of Xuan Loc

Amid the general collapse of South Vietnamese forces in spring 1975, the determined resistance of troops at Xuan Loc was a beacon of hope for President Thieu. Although the ARVN salvaged some honor, the North Vietnamese advance could not be halted.

◀◀ BEFORE

Although the ARVN fought well against communist forces directly after the 1973 Paris Peace Accords, South Vietnam's military and political position worsened drastically in 1974.

THIEU'S REGIME DWINDLES

The US Congress **blocked** further US military intervention in Vietnam and **sharply reduced funding for Saigon**. The resignation of Richard Nixon as US president in August 1974 was another blow to President Thieu. Victory for the NVA at **Phuoc Long** in December revealed that the ARVN was suffering from demoralization and a lack of finances. In March 1975, a communist **offensive** precipitated the break-up of the ARVN and a mass flight of civilians. Thieu's regime was left a small area around Saigon and the Mekong Delta.

The sudden collapse of South Vietnamese forces in March 1975 took the North Vietnamese leadership by surprise. Having not expected final victory before 1976, the North Vietnamese politburo altered its timetable. On March 25, NVA commander General Van Tien Dung was ordered to proceed to the capture of Saigon and the end of the war.

The ARVN took positions on the five main roads to Saigon in a defensive circle around the city. General Dung's forces were his enemy's superior in every way. He planned to avoid a battle inside the city by crushing each of the ARVN formations outside Saigon. Given the South Vietnamese troops' recent performance, it was reasonable to expect a swift victory.

Ultimate defense

At the eastern end of the ARVN defensive ring was the town of Xuan Loc. Standing on Route 1, almost 40 miles (65 km) from Saigon, it protected the vital air base at Bien Hoa as well as the road into the capital. Both sides recognized it as the keystone of the South Vietnamese defenses.

Xuan Loc was garrisoned by the previously undistinguished 18th ARVN Division, commanded by General Le Minh Dao. They faced the NVA IV Army Corps—three divisions with plentiful tanks and artillery. Despite the imbalance of forces, President Thieu ordered Xuan Loc held at all costs. General Dao told the world's media that however many divisions the communists sent against him, he would “smash them all.”

Spectacular resilience

On April 9, the NVA pounded Xuan Loc with artillery fire, while infantry and armored vehicles surged forward to overrun the defensive perimeter. ARVN resistance was unexpectedly resolute and the NVA suffered heavy losses of men and tanks. Counterattacks by ARVN troops from outside Xuan Loc meant the NVA diverted their resources from the assault to defend their flanks. On April 10, the NVA was forced to withdraw from positions they had seized in the town.

The spectacle of ARVN troops fighting with skill and dedication roused understandable excitement among supporters of the South Vietnamese government. Impressed with this display, the Ford administration pushed for a new American aid package, which they argued would allow the South Vietnamese to continue resisting the NVA. However,